

» As a contraction starts, repeat a word or phrase (in your mind or out loud), such as “love,” or “calm,” or your baby’s name if you’ve chosen it. Or choose a phrase such as “I feel powerful and strong.” Imagine the letters or words in front of you as you say the affirmation.

Q I’m planning to use a TENS machine for as long as possible. What do I need to know?

TENS is an acronym for Transcutaneous Electrical Nerve Stimulation. A TENS machine is a portable unit that emits low-voltage electrical impulses to your nerves via electrode pads secured on either side of your spine. When you have a contraction, you push a button to send impulses to your body, which are thought to stimulate the release of endorphins and to block your pain receptors. TENS is noninvasive, has no known harmful effects on you or your baby, and allows you to move around and feel in control of your pain relief. The only place it’s not possible to use your TENS machine is in water.

It can take up to an hour for endorphins to build up in your body, so as soon as you feel contractions, ask your birth partner to hook you up to the machine (it’s a good idea to practice before labor starts). You’ll be able to adjust the voltage of the electrical impulses to a comfortable level, increasing the frequency of the impulses as the pain gets more intense.

TENS machines are common in the UK, but they’re rarely used in the US, so you may have to shop online for a unit or have one shipped from abroad to get your hands on one.

Q Is acupuncture safe to use during labor, and will I be able to move?

Acupuncture is becoming increasingly common and popular as a form of pain relief during labor. This practice of inserting tiny needles at specific sites on the body is used to reduce pain sensitivity and encourage the release of endorphins. Acupuncture is safe to use during labor, but does require a trained acupuncturist. You will need to arrange to have an him or her there during labor. You might want to try a few sessions in pregnancy first. In labor, the acupuncturist is likely to work on points such as the ear, so that your movement isn’t restricted.

Q I’ve always found massage soothing. Will it help me in labor?

Massage during labor can help you to relax between contractions, release held-in tension, and alleviate lower back pain. Touch can be also calming and increase your confidence in your ability to deal with the pain of labor.

A study published in 2013 showed that women who were given a lower back massage for 30 minutes during established first stage labor reported significantly less pain than those who weren’t. The average lengths of the labors were roughly the same in both the massage and the control groups, and the physical therapists who performed the massage visited every woman in the control group for 30 minutes, too, but made no physical contact with them. The researchers concluded that massage has a measurably positive effect on the perception of pain.

If physical contact is something you find supportive and reassuring in everyday life,

encourage your birth partner to come to the massage sessions of your childbirth classes, or find an prenatal massage class that you can both attend. Practice the techniques during your pregnancy to get a good understanding of what feels best for you (both in terms of technique and pressure levels), so your birth partner is well-prepared to put the techniques into practice during your labor.

Some women find that when in labor they don’t want to be touched. It’s impossible to know how you’ll feel on the day, but discuss this possibility with your birth partner in advance so that he doesn’t take offence if you decide you don’t want to be touched at all.

SOOTHING MASSAGE

Experiment with the following techniques so you can ascertain which strokes you feel comfortable with and the ones you think might be helpful during labor.



Relaxing massage Both you and your partner should be in comfortable, supported positions during a massage session so that you can both relax fully.

» **Back sweep:** sit on a birthing stool or fold yourself over an exercise ball to expose your back. Ask your partner to run his hands from the outer sides of your shoulders inward, across your shoulder blades and down each side of your spine in one swooping, stroking motion. Repeat several times.

» **Tension release:** sit in a chair, on a stool, or on the edge of a bed and ask your partner to gently knead and squeeze the muscles of your shoulders and neck.

» **Relaxing head massage:** ask your partner to massage the top of your head, applying firm pressure with just the tips of his fingers, almost as if he is washing your hair.

» **Soothing touch:** if you don’t like the idea of being stroked in labor, ask your partner to hold your palm between his two palms, gently squeezing and releasing your hand. Many women find this simple contact deeply reassuring and nurturing.

» **Foot massage:** ask your partner to use firm thumb pressure all over the soles of your feet, rubbing, pressing, and making small circles to release knots and tension.